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Toshiba Protégé 3500

Welcome to tablet computing

Powered by Microsoft's initiatives in the area of tablet computing, the Toshiba Protégé 3500 is one of the first devices to feature the tablet edition of Windows XP Professional. At first glance, it looks exactly like a small notebook.

Tipping the scales at less than 2 kg, the Protégé 3500 measures 11.6 x 9.2 x 1.2 inches. It sports a matte black body with the touchpad and the swivel strip. The stylus is located right in the screen bezel, and the four hardware keys to be used in the tablet mode are located at the bottom right of the screen. The power switch and a small slider button needed to lock the power button are located at the other extreme end. You can use the lid latch to lock the LCD, even while in tablet mode.

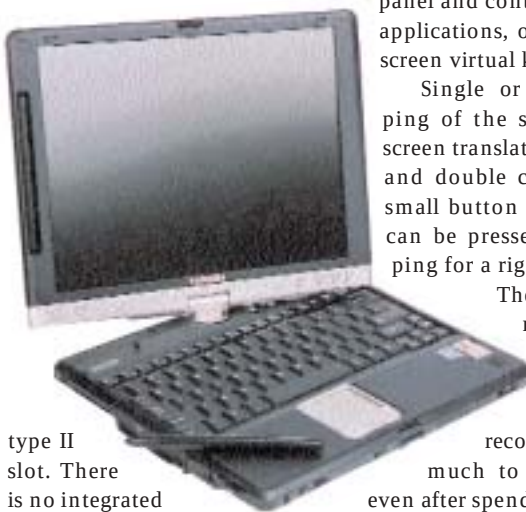
The Protégé is the transition between traditional mobile PCs and the radically new tablet computing. The 12.1-inch screen can rotate a full 180 degrees, and folded flat on top of the keyboard to activate the Tablet mode.

This baby boasts of a Pentium III 1.3 GHz mobile processor, with a 12.1-inch poly-silicon TFT colour display (supporting up to 16 million colours at a resolution of 1024 x 768).

Input options include an 84-key keyboard with 12 function keys, integrated touchpad, a tablet pen with the hovering feature and four hardware buttons. Connectivity

options include 10/100 Mbps Ethernet, integrated V.92 modem, infrared, integrated 802.11b wireless LAN and optional integrated Bluetooth. Two USB 2.0 ports and an RGB port provide support for external devices.

Expansion options include a user-accessible memory expansion slot, a type II/type I PC card slot, an SD card slot and a compact flash



type II slot. There is no integrated CD ROM or floppy drive, though an external CD ROM drive is bundled along.

It is strictly average in the standard notebook mode with a sturdy keyboard and well spaced keys. The touch-sensitive nature of the LCD reduces the viewing angle and the user needs to keep the screen straight to view colours and read text. The swivel ability of the screen has its advantages, but swivels only in one direction and is quite fragile.

The real fun starts when you switch to the tablet mode. The display orientation automatically changes to the portrait mode, and you can use the special features of Windows XP Tablet Edition. The input window for the handwriting and speech recognition feature is docked at the bottom of the screen.

You either use the Stylus to write text inside the input panel and control the active applications, or use the on-screen virtual keyboard.

Single or double tapping of the stylus on the screen translates to left click and double click, while a small button on the stylus can be pressed while tapping for a right-click.

The handwriting recognition is fairly accurate, but the Speech recognition leaves much to be desired—even after spending considerable time training the software. An external microphone may yield better results.

Windows Journal allows you to draw, write free-form and select handwriting to be translated into text. Other software bundled, includes Sensi-

va Symbol Command, a stylus-based access to and navigation functions. Zinio—a magazine reader.

The system is not initially a performance machine, but then meant to be—it yields 15 fps in normal mode and in high quality for Arena. The PIII 1.3 GHz and 256 MB of RAM is for most business applications.

The 2 Kg weight and battery life of 3 hours is short of a potential user's requirements. The system gets quite prolonged use. At a price of about Rs 2 lakh, the 3500 may not be the analyst to make tablet computing mainstream yet.

SPECIFICATIONS

Pentium III 1.3 GHz mobile processor, 256 MB SDRAM, 40 GB hard drive, 12.1-inch Poly-Silicon TFT, Trideer ALADDiN-T graphics card, Ali M1535 integrated sound, built-in speaker, phone, 84-key keyboard, integrated touchpad, a tablet pen, 10 Base-T/100 Ethernet, integrated V.92 modem, integrated 802.11b wireless LAN, optional integrated Bluetooth, two USB 2.0 ports, RGB port, one Type II/III PC card slot, one SD card slot, one Compact Flash Type I slot.

Price: Rs 1,99,999 plus taxes
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Toshiba Protégé 3500			
Performance	▶▶▶▶		
Build quality	▶▶▶▶		
Value for money	▶▶▶▶		
Features	▶▶▶▶		
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶		